

Designing the Right Activities

Ground Rules

Ground rules are the way that participants agree to engage and interact with each other during the workshop. By starting with ground rules, you signal that you care about making the workshop conducive for their learning. Ask participants, "In order to fully participate, and even to take risks and make mistakes, what ground rules would you need in place during this workshop?" Capture their suggestions on a poster, asking clarifying questions when needed. Ask "what else?" until the group is satisfied with the list.

Introductions

Help people connect with each other by having meaningful introductions. The truth is that people will be much more willing to take risks and make mistakes if they feel like they know the others in the group. Ask them to share something more personal, like their favorite meal or the superpower they wished they had. Over the day, get deeper with questions like "Tell us about a cherished childhood memory," or "Share a time you struggled. What did you do to move through it?"

Interactive Exercises

Give participants several opportunities to work together. Do a quick five-minute discussion in pairs, trios, or quads. That means that every person gets a chance to be heard, even if they don't speak in front of the large group. Occasionally, combine them into larger groups of six or eight people, extending time to 10–15 minutes. Have the group practice skills together. They can provide each other with valuable opportunities to practice, as well as offer suggestions, coaching, and encouragement.

There are a lot of online sources and books about effective group activities. Consider some of these:

- Seeds for Change, seedsforchange.org.uk
- Workshop Exercises, workshopexercises.com
- WorkshopBank, workshopbank.com
- Appreciative Inquiry Commons, appreciativeinquiry.champlain.edu/learn/resources-all
- Project Adventure, pa.org

Inclusion

As you consider your options to create connection, be sure you think about what will make your participants feel most included. Create groups that allow for even or odd numbers. Double check that every activity can be adapted to different physical abilities. And review your metaphors and analogies to make sure they represent a wide range of life experiences including economic backgrounds and resources, education, race, ethnicity, gender, age, spirituality, and sexual orientation. For your own development, be sure to pursue modern training on diversity, belonging, and inclusion. Check out the "Facilitators Guide to Making Meetings Accessible" research from Seeds for Change at seedsforchange.org.uk/accessiblemtg. I have found the work of Nanci Jiménez to be exceptional and transformational. Learn more at lunajimenezseminars.com.